

Associate Candidate Assignment

Expectations, Tips for Success, and Next Steps

AI integrity and acceptable use policy

Our organizational AI philosophy and practices are grounded in integrity and responsible use. We believe AI is a powerful tool to enhance and accelerate critical thinking, not replace it.

For this assignment, **we're interested in what you create, not what you copy**. The thoughts and perspectives you share need to be your own. Using AI as a **substitute for your own analysis, judgment, or reasoning is an explicit violation** of our AI integrity and acceptable use policy. You are prohibited from using AI during any live interview at ERS.

Within these guidelines, you're welcome to use AI. Please **disclose any AI use** on each relevant slide and/or within your Excel workbook by briefly noting that AI was used and describing the type of support it provided.

AI use is optional. We have the resources to teach AI fluency. This will be a skillset you'll (continue to) develop at ERS.

Timing

Prepare a **12-17-minute presentation** to share a summary of your findings, conclusions, and recommendations with your interviewer(s).

Your interviewer(s) will time your presentation. After **12 minutes**, they will give a **five-minute warning**, and at **17 minutes**, they will ask you to stop and move into **Q&A**. The Q&A portion is essential for them to understand your thinking.

Below is approximate breakdown of your 45-minute Zoom interview:

- Less than five minutes: Introductions
- 12–17 minutes: Your presentation
- 10 minutes: Questions from your interviewer(s)
- 10 minutes: Questions from you

Deliverables

Your completed candidate assignment must include the following items with appropriate AI citations:

- **Presentation (deck)**
 - If applicable, include one slide that summarizes how you leveraged AI to enhance and push your thinking.
- **One-page analyst note**
 - Outline your data cleaning steps, two hypotheses you tested that turned out to be wrong, and how you validated your finding(s).
- **Manipulated, organized data** set in Excel, Numbers or Google Sheets
 - All analysis must be conducted in one of these platforms.

Audience

Your project team colleagues are the intended audience of your presentation.

Tips for success

- Follow **all directions**.
 - This includes the length of your presentation. Practice. Time yourself.
- If your audience were the superintendent of District X, the presentation would be different. A **superintendent would be more focused on insights and actions and would care less about methodology and your thought process**.
- We want you to use **descriptive analysis** (e.g. graphs, tables, and summaries that highlight patterns and relationships in the data). This is the foundation of much of our quantitative work.
 - **Inferential statistical analyses** (e.g., r-squared, hypothesis significant tests, etc.) **are not required** and should not be your primary mode of analysis.
- **Leverage hypothesis-driven analysis**. Focus on the relationships and trends most likely to matter using your logical reasoning skills, knowledge base, and K-12 education research.
- We want you to **translate findings into insights**. Move beyond the “what” to the “so what” by translating discrete findings into a cohesive story with clear, actionable recommendations.
- We **strongly encourage you to use the provided deck template**, which also includes basic slide design principles that shape our work.

What happens after my second interview?

If you advance to a final interview, you will present an edited version of this presentation to a few different consultants. You will receive written feedback to inform these edits. However, **we also encourage you to take notes during the second interview to inform edits**.

Before we advance you to a virtual final interview, we may reconnect about your analytic exercise. Additional questions sometimes arise during the small group debrief following your second interview.

Final interviews occur via Zoom and are three to four hours. Breaks are included in this time. If you prefer to spread out your final interview over a couple of days, we can certainly explore this.

Please email people@erstrategies.org if you don't receive a candidacy update within two weeks **or if this timeline doesn't align with your search needs**.